A Moment Beside the River

Last year, my family and I went to Alaska on a cruise. During our visit to Skagway, we took a train through the woods along the edge of a mountain. As the train moved, cool air flowed around me, carrying the earthy smell of mud and wood. Below me, green trees covered the slopes, stretching down farther than I could see. The sky was bright, and the air felt fresh. All of a sudden, a river appeared through the trees. Pale water rushed between large gray rocks, breaking into white swirls as it moved through the forest. I was astonished by how fast and powerful the water looked. Yet right beside it, the trees stood straight and green. In such a cold place, I was surprised that I could not see any yellow leaves. The river seemed strong enough to sweep anything away, but the trees remained standing beside it. Watching the rushing water and the still trees together made me feel the majesty of nature. With the air moving around me and the woods stretching below, I felt like I was part of the landscape, even though I was riding on a train.

Looking at the picture now, I see the person I want to become in those trees. They stand beside the rushing water like people who refuse to back down or fall, no matter how hard life hits them. To me, the river represents difficulties that I cannot always control, while the trees show the strength to face them without giving up. I cannot see their roots, but I imagine them as the beliefs that keep a person steady. This connects to Emerson's idea of self-reliance: trusting my own judgment when I face pressure instead of letting others decide everything for me. The trees also help me think about individualism. They stand on their own, but they are still part of the forest around them. In the same way, I can stay true to myself while belonging to a larger world. My feeling on the train also reminds me of the Over-Soul, the transcendentalist idea of a spiritual unity connecting people and nature. I could see the river, smell the woods, and feel the air, so nature felt close to me in that moment. I was only passing through, but I felt connected to something much larger than myself. The photograph captures the trees and river, but it cannot capture the air I felt. Remembering that moment reminds me to pay attention to the world around me and find meaning in what I experience for myself.